HILCHOT SHABBAT

Mashing & Kneading: Where Food Prep Becomes a Melakhah

Given Thursday 29 October 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 321:9-14

Sefer: Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim, Siman 321 (סימן שכ"א)

Seifim covered: 9–13 and 19 (completing tochen, with the Rema), then the introduction to **lash** (Seifim 14–16 come next week).

Topic: The last heterim of **מלאכת טוחן**: cooked meat and fish, grating cheese, why a **grater is muktzeh but an egg slicer is not**, cutting **דק דק**, the **Rashba's heter of grinding סמוך לסעודה** (and whether Sefardim rely on it), and finishing what was already mostly crushed. A practical summary sheet of tochen. Then **מלאכת לש**: the **machloket Rabbi and Rabbi Yosi bar Rabbi Yehuda** (is putting the water in already kneading?), the **Weetabix** case, and the three levels of mixture: **בלילה עבה, בלילה רכה**, and no mixture at all.

Schedule note: Thursday, 6:00–7:00pm on Zoom. *"We will be continuing in Hilchot Shabbat until at least we finish this chapter, for the time being."*

Where We Are

- **Siman 321** has three big topics: **pickling**, **tochen** (crushing) and **lash** (kneading).
- **Last week:**
- **Pickling (עיבוד באוכלים):** a rabbinic prohibition, either because it resembles **tanning (מעבד)**, as Rashi explains, or because it resembles **cooking (בישול)**, as the Rambam explains. We went through when salting is permitted and when it is not.
- **Tochen:** grinding, crushing, mashing, and even **cutting very small**, all forbidden. We learned the first three heterim (below).
- **Tonight:** finish tochen, then begin *"a major and really complicated, but we will make it clear,"* **מלאכת לש**.

Part One — Completing מלאכת טוחן

Recap: the first three heterim

#	Heter	What it means	Example
1	**שינוי גדול** (Seif 7)	Crushing with the **back of a knife or the underside of a cup**: such an extreme deviation that the melacha becomes permitted	Mashing avocado with the back of a fork; crushing pepper with a knife handle
2	**אין טוחן אחר טוחן**	Something already ground and reconstituted may be ground again	Crumbling bread back into "flour"; **crushing crackers by hand**
3	**Already edible + not גידולי קרקע** (Seif 9)	Two מחלוקות ראשונים combined	Cooked meat and chicken may be cut very fine

Two conditions on heter 1:

- It may not be done **into or onto a place set aside for grinding**: a regular **chopping board is fine**, a **mortar is not**.
- The Rabbi promised a **summary sheet** of common tochen questions, *"which I wrote some time ago"* (below).

Seif 9 — Cooked meat, raw meat

מותר לחתוך בשר מבושל או צלי דק דק בסכין.

You may cut cooked or roasted meat **very finely** with a knife, in the **regular way**: not with a shinui, and it was never ground before. **Why?** Two machlokot combine:

Machloket	One side	The other side	Halacha
Does tochen apply to food that is already edible?	**Most Rishonim:** yes, even edible food	**The Ba'al HaTerumah** (and possibly the Rambam, *"though that's debatable"*): tochen only applies to **inedible** food, which the crushing makes edible	We **don't** follow the lenient view: the Shulchan Aruch applies tochen **even to vegetables**
Are animals גידולי קרקע? (**אין טוחן אלא בגידולי קרקע**)	They don't grow from the ground; they are born from animals	They get **all their nutrition from the ground**	Debatable

Together, Maran permits cutting what is **already edible** and **comes from an animal**: cooked meat and cooked chicken.

The sushi example: a big piece of **raw salmon** isn't edible as it is, but cut into tiny pieces with something else, it is. That is the kind of "making edible" the Ba'al HaTerumah means.

אבל אסור לחתוך דק דק בשר חי לפני העופות, הואיל ואינם יכולים לאכלו בלא חיתוך, כמשוי ליה אוכל.

- **Raw meat** (or raw fish in a big piece) may **not** be cut very fine, e.g. for birds, *"or for anyone for that matter,"* because you are **making it edible**.

But even with cooked meat, no specialised instrument. You may crush cooked meat, fish or chicken, **but not with a grinder**:

1. grinders are **muktzeh**;
2. every heter we have learned works **only without a specialised instrument**.

Seif 10 — Grating cheese

אסור לגרור הגבינה בשבת במורג חרוץ בעל פיפיות שקורין ראליו.

Work it through:

- **(a)** Cheese is **edible before grating**.
- **(b)** Cheese doesn't come from something that grows from the ground. So **cheese may be mashed, crushed and grated completely on Shabbat**. You don't even need the combination of Seif 9.
- **However:** you **may not use an instrument designated for grating**. That is the prohibition of this seif.

The same applies to eggs: boiled eggs may be **mashed** (cooked, and from an animal rather than directly from the ground), but **not with a grater or a masher**. That would be an **איסור דרבנן**: *"Chachamim forbade all kinds of special instruments, and thus all of these instruments become muktzeh on Shabbos."*

Slicers are different

Utensil	What it does during the week	Shabbat
Grater, mincer, garlic crusher, onion chopper, mouli	Grates or crushes: **tochen**	**Forbidden** (and muktzeh)
Egg slicer, cheese slicer	**Only slices**, never grinds	**Permitted**

"Even during the week all it's doing is slicing. It's not crushing, it's not grating, it's not doing מלאכת טוחן."

Robert: isn't cheese from the ground too?

Robert: *The milk came from the cow, and the cow ate from the ground, and the milk made the cheese. Why isn't cheese גידולי קרקע?*

The Rabbi: *"No, because it's quite far, and it's not the milk itself. It's a whole procedure."* Cheese has **its own new status**. **Meat or an egg, directly from the animal**, are still **potentially** גידולי קרקע. **Cheese clearly isn't.**

Seif 11 — Water for vegetables (a side point)

מותר להשקות התלוש כדי שלא יכמוש.

- Not our topic: it relates to **kotzer**, which we touched on long ago.

- **Background:** Chachamim forbade **putting things into water** on Shabbat because of **tircha** (bother). Drawing water used to be a long procedure. That is why the Mishnah in Sukkah says **don't change the water for the lulav** on Yom Tov.
- **But for food purposes it is permitted:** you may put vegetables in water **so they don't wither**.

Seif 12 — Cutting very fine

המחתך הירק דק דק, חייב משום טוחן.

- **A fourth form of tochen** beyond grinding, crushing and mashing: **cutting into very small pieces.**
- **How small? שיעור דקותן לא נודע לנו**: *"we don't know the measure of its fineness."* (The Rabbi thinks it's the **Sefer Mitzvot Gedolot** who says this.) Already the early Rishonim didn't know.

The Rema: ויש אומרים דאסור לחתוך גרוגרות וחרובים לפני הזקנים... אבל מותר לפרר הלחם לפני התרנגולים, כיון דכבר נטחן... דאין טוחן אחר טוחן.

- You may not cut **figs, dates** or carobs very small **"in front of the elderly"**.
- **The Magen Avraham** says it's **davka** (only for the elderly), but **everyone disagrees**: it's **אורחא דמילתא**, just the usual reason you'd cut so small.
- But **bread** may be crumbled, for chickens or anyone, because of **אין טוחן אחר טוחן**.

Heter 4 — The Rashba: grinding סמוך לסעודה

The Rema: וכל זה לא מיירי אלא לחתוך ולהניח, אבל אם לאכלו מיד הכל שרי, מידי דהוי אבורר לאכול מיד דשרי. (תשובת הרשב"א)

The source:

- In **borer** (learned in the summer) the **Gemara itself** permits selecting **for immediate consumption**, **סמוך לסעודה**.
- *"To the best of my knowledge, the Rashba is the first one"* to say the same applies to **tochen**. It is **not in the Gemara**.

What it permits:

- Even with **none of the first three heterim** (no shinui, never ground before, never cooked), you may **mash a banana in the regular way** if you're about to **feed it to your baby now**.

The Biur Halacha explains why it can even be done **with a knife**, unlike borer, where immediate selection is only permitted without a kli:

> **דכמו בבורר דרך אכילה הוא... והכא נמי... אפילו כשחותך בסכין לאכול לאלתר דרך אכילה היא, ומשום שאינה מיוחדת לטחינה.**

- **Cutting with a knife to eat right away is the way of eating**, and a knife isn't designated for grinding.

The Beit Yosef brings the Rashba but adds: **if you can cut slightly bigger pieces, it's good**, because it's **the Rashba's chiddush**, not the Gemara's.

Can we rely on it?

Posek	Position	Reasoning
Ben Ish Chai (*"as far as I remember"*)	**Don't rely on it at all**	The **Shulchan Aruch didn't codify it**, though the Beit Yosef brought it, so perhaps Maran didn't hold of it in the end
Chacham Ovadia	**Mutar me'ikar hadin**	The Shulchan Aruch **doesn't codify everything** in the Beit Yosef (mainly what is in the Gemara). The **Beit Yosef never said he disagrees**, only *"if possible, cut bigger"*. And the **Rema brings it as halacha**

The practical upshot (Chacham Ovadia):

- **Any** crushing, mashing or tochen is permitted **סמוך לסעודה**: for the meal you are about to eat, **"certainly in the next 5–10 minutes"** (as in Hilchot Borer).
- **If you can cut bigger pieces, תבוא עליו ברכה.** But it's fine **me'ikar hadin** even if you don't.
- *"Not everyone agrees to this, but there's plenty to rely on."*

"Major heter." You wake up on Shabbat and want to **mash a banana for the baby**: permitted. You can't find a knife to mash the **avocado** with the back of it, and you want to mix it with oil and eat it **now** with your crackers or challah: permitted. Preparing in the kitchen the meal you're about to eat **in a few minutes**: permitted.

Seif 19 — Finishing what was mostly crushed (heter 5)

שום, בוסר ומלילות שריסקן מערב שבת, ומחוסרין דיכה, אסור לגמור דיכתן בשבת. ואם אינן מחוסרין אלא שחיקה... מותר.

Three Hebrew stages of crushing (remember them as רד"ש):

Stage	Hebrew	Meaning	On Shabbat, if this is what remains
1	**ריסוק**	Beginning to break it down	—
2	**דיכה**	More thoroughly ground	**Forbidden** to finish
3	**שחיקה**	Completely ground	**Permitted** to finish

- **The example:** before Shabbat you broke down **baked potatoes**, but they aren't fully mashed. On Shabbat you may **finish making mashed potato**, since it was **mainly done** already.

  לפיכך מותר לגמור שחיקת הריפות בעץ פרור בקדרה בשבת, when they were put on the fire before Shabbat.
- *"I don't know how practical it is. One or two cases."*

The Rema — ממרח doesn't apply to food

There is a **melacha of ממרח** (spreading, smoothing), but it **doesn't apply to foods**:

- you may **spread avocado** on bread (mash it in a permitted way, then spread);
- **chocolate spread** on bread is fine.

The Rabbi's Tochen Summary Sheet

"A document which I composed some time ago, about eight, nine years ago... I just came across it this week, b'siyata dishmaya. It had been buried somewhere for a good few years." (He offered to put it on the group.)

Definition

- In the Mishkan, after **borer** the seeds were **ground into a fine powder**, sieved, made into a paste, baked, and made into a **dye**.
- **Tochen** = grinding, or cutting into **minute** pieces (**דק דק**, measure unclear, but it must be very small).
- **It applies to non-edibles too:** the Rambam and the Gemara talk about crushing a **clod of earth**. *"We'll talk in a moment about mud on your jacket."*
- **Implements:** a mincer, chopper, fork or knife is **de'oraita** when crushing completely.
- **By hand:** it is rabbinic **unless** that is the usual manner.
- **Crushing a clod of soil by hand** is the usual way, so **de'oraita**.
- **Food** isn't usually crushed by hand, so mashing a banana by hand to leave for later is a **shinui**: **not de'oraita**, but still forbidden.

Forms of tochen

Form	Examples
Grinding / crushing (Seifim 7–8)	Grain into flour, coffee beans into powder, **pepper**, dry **hadassim** leaves (*"you can do this by mistake... the hadassim go dry very quickly"*)
Mashing (Seif 12)	Avocado, banana, dates, figs
Shredding / grating	Onions and vegetables

Specialised utensils can never be used, even on a product you may grind: a mincer, grater, onion chopper, garlic crusher or mouli. This is because of **עובדין דחול**.

The five permitted methods

#	Heter	Rule	Practical
1	**שינוי גדול**	Handle of a knife, underside of a cup. **Even long before the meal**, even **completely**	Not into a mortar. A **chopping board is fine**, since it's also used for regular cutting. Avocado and banana with the back of a knife, then spread
2	**אין טוחן אחר טוחן** (Seifim 8, 12)	Already ground before	**Sugar cubes** (refined sugar), bread, biscuits, cake, matzah, **medication tablets** (*"constituted from already-ground stuff"*), **snuff** that hardened (the Ben Ish Chai). No specialised utensil
3	**Not from the ground + already edible**	Combination of poskim	**Cooked meat**; **fish need not even be cooked** (*"I should have made this clearer"*: fish are **not** גידולי קרקע); **cheese, eggs, liver**, even **long before the meal, in the usual manner**
4	**סמוך לסעודה** (the Rashba)	**טוחן דרך אכילה**	Debatable, so **cut slightly larger** if you can: **תבוא עליו ברכה** (Chacham Ovadia)
5	**Mostly crushed already** (Seif 19)	Needs **ריסוק** and **דיכה** done, only **שחיקה** lacking	Finish mashing potatoes or cooked carrots

Practical examples

- **Mashing banana or avocado** (for babies or anyone): permitted **with the back of a knife**. **Spreading** is fine: **no ממרח with food**.
- **A very small salad** (tomato, cucumber, pepper):
- **peeling** must be close to the meal because of **borer**, preferably **with a knife, not a peeler**. (Chacham Ovadia allows a peeler, since the peel is **גוף אחד**, one body with the vegetable, but a knife is better.)
- You may take the **stem off tomatoes**.
- **Don't cut too small** unless it's **right before the meal**.
- **A tiny "falafel" salad:** cut **very close to the meal**, preferably **a bit larger** than usual.
- **Salting cucumbers** (from last week): salt **together with oil or lemon**, or **oil first**, to avoid the **pickling** issue.
- **Egg and onion:** shell the eggs close to the meal (borer). **No tochen with egg**, and an **egg slicer** may be used. **Chopping the onion small** must be **right before the meal**.

Mud

Case	Ruling	Why
Dry mud on your body (e.g. running in shorts)	**May be removed**, even though it's a **פסיק רישא** that it crumbles	Only **derabbanan**; you have **no interest** in grinding it; **כבוד הבריות**
Mud on your clothes	**You** may not remove it	
	You may **ask a non-Jew** to take off the layer of mud	**שבות דשבות במקום כבוד הבריות**
A **stain** you want washed out	**Generally not**, even through a non-Jew	That involves **water**: *"a whole different question... de'oraita"*

Two rabbinic prohibitions connected to tochen

Gezeirah	Source	Today
Things that make a noise	**Tosafot:** you may not put wheat in a **millstone** before Shabbat, because the noise makes people think you started it on Shabbat. From here, the **Ashkenazi** prohibition on leaving anything set before Shabbat that **makes a loud noise**	**Washing machines:** *"I don't know washing machines which make noise nowadays."* Even Ashkenazim would likely be allowed; **for Sefardim it's straight out mutar**. **Rav Moshe Feinstein:** an **alarm clock** is permitted, since its whole nature is to be set beforehand, so the gezeirah never covered it
שחיקת סממנים	Medicines used to be made by **grinding plants**, so Chachamim restricted **taking medicine** on Shabbat	A whole chapter, **Siman 328**, *"in a couple of months' time"*

Seif 13 — Honey from the hive (before lash)

אסור לרדות דבש מן הכוורת... מפני שדומה לתולש.

- You may not take honey **from the honeycomb**, because it **resembles detaching (kotzer)**.
- Kotzer normally means **detaching something from its source of growth**. Honey doesn't *grow* in the comb, it was **made** there, but **Chachamim forbade it rabbinically**.
- Honey **already out of the comb**, or floating on top: **permitted**.

Part Two — מלאכת לש (Kneading): An Introduction

"One of the most misunderstood melachot"

- *"I think it's one of the most misunderstood melachot, if not the most misunderstood."*
- In the many contemporary books on the melachot, in Hebrew and English, *"I have not come across a sefer which properly goes through לש in a really structured manner."*
- **The Orchot Shabbat** was very good, *"probably the best,"* but it's **for Ashkenazim**.
- **For Sefardim**, *"I don't know a sefer which goes through לש properly."*

- **Where it's found:** only a few seifim: **Siman 321, Seifim 14–16**; **Siman 324**; and **Siman 340**. *"We will learn those two because we have to learn the whole לש together."*
- **The plan:** at least next week, maybe another shiur after that. *"When you understand the principles, it all makes total sense, and it's very easy to apply."*

A preview of the Rabbi's practical list (to come at the end):

- **techina**;
- **aubergine salad** with oil or mayonnaise;
- **chilbe (חילבה)**;
- **coleslaw**;
- **potato salad** with mayonnaise;
- **egg and onion** with oil or mayonnaise;
- **avocado** with lemon;
- **banana salads**;
- **thick yoghurt with banana**;
- **cornflakes** in thick yoghurt (*"not Weetabix, Weetabix is something separate"*);
- **porridge, pudding, jelly**.

What is lash?

- **The tenth melacha.** In making the dye: plant, harvest, thresh, select (borer), grind (**tochen**), and now **knead** the powder with liquid, then cook it.
- **Definition: gathering together, through a liquid, things that were not gathered before**, transforming separate particles into **a paste-like, unified mass**.
- **The liquid** can be anything that binds: **water, fruit juice, milk, oil**.
- **Lash applies to non-edibles too.**

The fundamental machloket: is putting the water in already kneading?

Making challah has **two stages**:

מגבל / נתינה: putting the ingredients together (water onto flour);

גיבול: kneading it with your hands into dough.

Kneading is clearly lash. **Is stage one lash too?**

Shabbat 18a: מאן תנא נתינת מים לדיו זו היא שרייתן? אמר רב יוסף: רבי היא, דתניא: אחד נותן את הקמח ואחד נותן את המים, האחרון חייב, דברי רבי. רבי יוסי בר יהודה אומר: אינו חייב עד שיגבל.

	Rabbi (Yehuda HaNasi)	Rabbi Yosi bar Rabbi Yehuda
Putting the liquid in	**Already lash.** Whoever adds the second ingredient, the one that begins the mingling, is **chayav**	**Not chayav**
Chayav when?	At the mingling; and kneading is **a second toldah** of lash	**Only when you knead (עד שיגבל)**
Mixed before Shabbat?	You **still** can't knead it together on Shabbat	Mixing alone was never the issue

Why the halacha doesn't simply follow Rabbi

- Normally **הלכה כרבי מחבירו**: Rabbi, the author of the Mishnah, usually prevails.
- **But the Rambam, the Rif and most Rishonim rule like Rabbi Yosi**, because of a **סתם משנה**: **נותנין מים למורסן, אבל לא גובלין**. You may **add water to bran**, but **not knead** it.
- The **anonymous Mishnah** is the default position, and **הלכה כסתם משנה** trumps **הלכה כרבי מחבירו**.
- **The Rambam: הלש כגרוגרת חייב... המגבל את עפרה זו היא לישה**. **The melacha is the kneading.**
- **Other Rishonim**, such as the **Semag**, the **Ba'al HaTerumah** and **Rabbi Baruch of Mainz**: **halacha follows Rabbi**, despite the stam Mishnah.

How the Shulchan Aruch rules

	Ruling
Shulchan Aruch (here in **321** and in **324:3**)	**יש אומרים**: like the **Rambam and Rif**: lash is **the kneading**. Then a **סתם** the **Ba'al HaTerumah and Semag**
Rema	**We are machmir** like the Ba'al HaTerumah and Semag. **Ashkenazim:** even the **mingling** is a problem
Ben Ish Chai, Kaf HaChaim, Or LeTzion (Rav Ben Zion Abba Shaul)	Since Maran brought the second opinion **in both places**, **one should try to be machmir** and treat the mingling as a problem
Chacham Ovadia (following the **Chida**)	A **סתם ויש** means the halacha is like the **סתם**. The **יש אומרים** is brought **משום כבודו**, so you **know** there's another opinion: *"you don't need to follow it."* **The mingling is not the problem; the kneading is**

On the "rules" of reading the Shulchan Aruch: *"The honest truth is, I believe all of these rules are not really rules. For every rule... you have rules which go against it."* The Shulchan Aruch's purpose was to **summarise the Beit Yosef**: *"this is the main opinion, but you should know there is a second opinion."*

The shiur proceeds like Chacham Ovadia, the Rambam and the Rif: the melacha is the kneading.

Crucial caveat: when mixing *is* the kneading

"Extremely important caveat. This is something people don't know. I've seen people do this on Shabbos, and I think it's a melacha d'oraita."

Some mixtures bind by themselves the moment you combine them. Then **even Rabbi Yosi agrees you're chayav** with the mixing itself. *"Not begins: happens!"*

Weetabix with a little milk (*"Again, I haven't seen anyone who discusses this, but לעניות דעתי I think this is pashut"*):

- With **lots of milk**, *"that's less of an issue. Let's talk about that later."*
- But some like their Weetabix **"very stodgy"** and pour in **a bit of milk**. The milk is **completely absorbed** and **binds the crumbly Weetabix into one unified mass**.
- **The pouring itself is the lash.**

The source, Siman 340: הנותן זרע פשתן או שומשמין במים חייב משום לש, מפני שמתערבים ונתלים זה בזה.

- **Sesame or flax seeds** put into water **mix and cling together by themselves**, so putting them in is chayav **even according to Rabbi Yosi**.

The three levels of mixture

The result determines the severity:

Level	Hebrew	What it looks like	Examples	Status (kneading, following Rabbi Yosi)
1	**בלילה עבה** (mixture thick)	**Barely moves**; if it moves, **extremely laboriously**	**Dough**; **toothpaste** mixed with something	**Chayav d'oraita**
2	**בלילה רכה** (mixture thin)	Unified and stays together, but **moves when you tilt it**, poured easily. Not runny	**Cake batter**	**Rabbinic**
3	**No בלילה**	**Runny**, not a mixture at all	**Hot chocolate**: cocoa powder into water	**Mutar**

"Those are the three levels of לש." (The precise definitions come *"only much later on"* in the Shulchan Aruch.)

Summary

Tochen: five heterim

1. **A שינוי גדול**: the back of a knife or the underside of a cup, onto a chopping board, never a mortar.

אין טוחן אחר טוחן: bread, crackers, sugar cubes, tablets, snuff.

3. **Already edible and not from the ground**:
4. **cooked meat and chicken**;

5. **fish even raw**;
6. **cheese, eggs and liver** outright.

   Chacham Ovadia permits it me'ikar hadin, preferably :(the Rashba, via the Rema) **סמוך לסעודה** .cutting a little bigger; the **Ben Ish Chai** doesn't rely on it

8. **Mostly crushed before Shabbat** (only שחיקה lacking): finish it.

Tochen: always

- **No specialised utensils**: graters, mincers, crushers are muktzeh. **Slicers are fine.**
- **Raw meat** may not be cut very fine.

  .doesn't apply to food **ממרח**
- **Mud** may be brushed off the body, and off clothes through a non-Jew.

Lash

- **Gathering separate particles into one mass through a liquid.**
- **Rabbi vs Rabbi Yosi bar Rabbi Yehuda:**
- **Maran and Chacham Ovadia:** only **the kneading** is lash.
- **Ashkenazim** (the Rema) and some Sefardi poskim: **even the mingling**.
- **But if the mixing itself binds** (**Weetabix with a little milk**, sesame in water), **the pouring is lash** according to all.

  .derabbanan; **no mixture** = mutar = **בלילה רכה** ;de'oraita = **בלילה עבה**

Coming Up

- **Next week:**
- a quick review of these principles, *"lay out a couple more things"*;
- then **Siman 321, Seifim 14–16** in the Shulchan Aruch;
- then *"flesh this out in practical examples and see how we can actually do לש on Shabbos."*
- **At least one more shiur after that** on lash, with **Siman 324** and **Siman 340**, and the Rabbi's practical list:
- techina, aubergine salad, coleslaw, potato salad, egg and onion;
- avocado, yoghurt and cereal, Weetabix, porridge, pudding, jelly.

Shabbat Shalom.

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